

Chapter 1 Reading Slowly

1.1 Why Read Slowly

A reader who moves slowly is not wasting time. Each sentence is a small claim, and a careful reader checks whether the claim fits with what came before. When it does not fit, that friction is useful: it marks the place where understanding is about to change.

Speed hides these moments. Skimming produces a feeling of familiarity without the structure underneath it. The goal of this book is to make the slow path lighter, not shorter.

Fixture marker for page 1: AMBER.

1.2 Building a Model

To build a model of a text is to hold its parts in relation. Which idea depends on which? What would break if one sentence were removed? A model is something you can run forward: given a new case, it predicts what the author would say.

Questions are the tool for building such a model. A good question names a specific passage and asks how it connects to something else. A vague question gets a vague answer.

Fixture marker for page 2: BIRCH.

When you return to a passage you questioned before, the old question is a map. It shows where you were confused and what resolved the confusion. Keeping those questions next to the text turns a single reading into a record you can revisit.

The end of a section is a natural place to stop and check. Can you say, without looking, what the section claimed and why? If not, the model is not yet built.

Fixture marker for page 3: CEDAR.

Chapter 2 Numbers on the Page

2.1 Growth

Many books explain change with numbers. A quantity that grows by the same fraction each step grows faster and faster in absolute terms, even though the rule never changes.

Suppose a value doubles every step. After ten steps it is about a thousand times larger. After twenty steps it is about a million times larger. The rule is simple; the consequences are not.

Fixture marker for page 4: DAHLIA.

2.2 A Few Formulas

Formulas compress an argument into a line. The text layer of a PDF often breaks them apart, so a reader who marks a formula should also see it as an image.

$$\int_0^1 x^2 dx = \frac{1}{3} \tag{1}$$

$$\sum_{k=1}^n k = \frac{n(n+1)}{2} \tag{2}$$

$$e^{i\pi} + 1 = 0, \quad \alpha \leq \beta \tag{3}$$

Each of these lines rewards slow reading. Try to say in words what each symbol stands for before moving on.

Fixture marker for page 5: EMBER.

A formula is only understood when you can use it. Pick a small value of n , compute both sides of the sum by hand, and check that they agree. The check takes a minute and leaves a trace in memory that rereading does not.

If a step in a derivation is not clear, mark it and ask about that step alone. Asking about the whole page at once tends to produce a summary rather than an explanation.

Fixture marker for page 6: FJORD.

Chapter 3 Summaries

3.1 In Your Own Words

Writing a summary in your own words is harder than reading one written by someone else. That difficulty is the point. The effort of choosing words forces you to decide what mattered.

A summary does not need to be complete. It needs to be yours. Three honest sentences are worth more than a paragraph copied from the text.

Fixture marker for page 7: GARNET.

3.2 Finding the Gap

After you write a summary, it helps to learn what you left out. Not a rewrite, and not a list of every omission: one gap, the most important one, is enough to act on.

Then go back to the text and find where that idea lives. Reading it a second time, with a question in mind, is different from reading it the first time.

Fixture marker for page 8: HARBOR.